

COMP 3700A: Contributing to Open Source

Navigating Large Codebases

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Housekeeping

- Do we have notetakers for [today's topics](#)?
 - Goal is to have the PR for each topic submitted within **1 week**
 - After submission, I will add a reviewer — you may request specific topic
 - If you are chosen as reviewer, you may decline the invitation
- How are things going on part 1 of the project?
 - Presentations next week!

Today's Goals

- Non-code contributions
- Navigating large codebases

Non-code contributions

- At a certain scale, FOSS projects need all kinds of expertise
- Documentation in its [various forms](#)
- UI/UX designers
- Translators
- Bug reporters and triagers
- [Your examples](#)

Navigating large codebases

- Situation: you've found a **bite-sized issue** and now you want to solve it
- Where do you even start?
- Lots of manual tracing, but also language server (LSP) and `grep`
- Worth knowing a bit of [regular expressions](#)

Example: a random issue from [Matplotlib](#)

More complicated: a random issue from [Audacity](#)

Some basic regex

- **Basic characters**
 - A literal character (e.g. `A`, `x`, `4`, `?`)
 - Some of these need an escape character (`\`)
- **Any of some type:**
 - `\d` : any digit
 - `\w` : any "word" character (`Aa-Zz`, `0-9`, `_`)
 - `\W` : any non-word character
 - `\s` : any whitespace
 - `\S` : any non-whitespace

Example: write an expression to find `TODO` items

Multipliers and grouping stuff

- `*` : 0 or more
- `+` : 1 or more
- `?` : 0 or 1
- `{#}` : exactly `#`
- `[ ]` : any of the things in `[ ]`
- `(?:)` : exact sequence after the `:`

Example: write an expression to find Python class declarations, including `class X:` and `class X(Y):`, but not other mentions of the word `class`

Boundaries

- `\b` : A word boundary
- `\B` : Not a word boundary
- `^` : start of a line or string*
- `$` : end of a line or string

* unless inside `[]`, then the `^` character means NOT

Example: write an expression to find `int` declarations in C++ or Java

What about AI?

- AI does not ingest your entire codebase, it just `grep`s for you
 - For example, my [session log](#) with Copilot about Audacity
- I guess it works, kinda... but I used 1% of my monthly AI credits included with GitHub Education and I still know nothing about the code!
- I recommend you try doing your own tracing rather than taking the LLM shortcut (but definitely use LSP features)

Git tools: who and when

- `git blame filename` : line-by-line listing of commits
- `git log -L :funcname:filename` : history of specific function in file
- `git grep` : Like regular grep, but only searches tracked files and can search previous commits

Coming up next

Wednesday: Truth and Reconciliation day, no classes

Thursday: No lab, come to the [Tech Transition Event](#)

Also, no homework since your project part 1 is due Friday!